

Understanding and Supporting Financially-Constrained Aspiring Entrepreneurs' Entrepreneurial Transitions

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ABSTRACT

Entrepreneurship is perceived as a promising path to financial stability, especially for those with financial constraints. Still, the transition to entrepreneurship is not easy. Financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs, many of whom are racial minorities, must overcome many challenges to achieve their goals. This includes obtaining access to mentorship, financial capital, and digital support for their businesses. In my dissertation, I examine how existing sociotechnical interventions, including social media and community-based-organization (CBO)-supported interventions, can support their entrepreneurial transitions, especially as a provision of informational and emotional support. Early findings from my dissertation research suggest that CBO-supported peer group interventions provide a source of informational and emotional support, helping financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs make progress toward their goals and overcome setbacks. In my dissertation, I aim to unpack the factors that contribute to the success of such groups and contribute design opportunities for sociotechnical interventions to better support financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' work-role transition processes.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

KEYWORDS

entrepreneurship, identity transitions, low-resource communities

ACM Reference Format:

Aarti Israni. 2024. Understanding and Supporting Financially-Constrained Aspiring Entrepreneurs' Entrepreneurial Transitions. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '24)*, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 5 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3638193>

1 BACKGROUND & MOTIVATION

Transitioning to any work role often entails creating and adapting to new work-role identities. For individuals trying to become

entrepreneurs, identity construction and adaptation are important to achieve legitimacy [39, 44], belonging [44, 47] and commitment towards their businesses [44]. For many individuals in financially-constrained communities, entrepreneurship is perceived as a promising path to financial stability and an opportunity to positively contribute to their communities [27]. Still, for community members, many of whom are racial minorities, becoming an entrepreneur is not easy. In addition to navigating limited access to financial capital for launching a business, research suggests that when compared to their white counterparts, minority entrepreneurs face many challenges to achieving their goals. Such hurdles include reduced access to social networks [10, 25, 33], financial capital [6, 10], and digital support for their businesses [4]. For aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained communities, identity construction and adaptation are pivotal as the social and financial hurdles they must navigate may pose challenges to their abilities to successfully start their businesses. Such challenges can constrain their abilities to achieve legitimacy, belonging, and commitment.

According to work-role transition scholarship, individuals navigate three key phases to successfully construct and adapt to new work role identities. These include the *exploration* of possible and desired work-role identities, *provisional trial* of work-role identities, and an *evaluation* of individuals' current and desired work-role identities [2, 28]. In each phase, informational and emotional support is pivotal; this can include but is not limited to advice, validation, and feedback [2, 28]. Past research suggests that interactions with peers, individuals navigating similar entrepreneurial transitions, can be an important source of informational and emotional support to aspiring entrepreneurs [1, 15, 29, 35, 37]. Unlike the traditional advising and mentorship relationships afforded by small business development centers and entrepreneurship programs, peer advising and support relationships provide aspiring entrepreneurs with empathy, validation, sense of community and critical perspectives from people who often share similar experiences and challenges [19, 37, 51]. For aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained communities, access to peers who share similar race and class-based identities, may be an even more invaluable source of informational and emotional support as they navigate similar racial and class-based challenges that may disproportionately impede their abilities to become entrepreneurs [5, 50].

While social media are emerging as tools to help facilitate access to informational and emotional support from peers [48], the benefits are realized by those who feel comfortable disclosing their identity and resource needs [40]. However, research has suggested

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CHI EA '24, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA
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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0331-7/24/05
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3638193>

that perceived online norms [11, 31, 40], difference in communication practices [3, 23, 49], and preferences to establish interpersonal trust before disclosing resource needs [31], may prevent financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs from disclosing their resource needs and obtaining relevant resources online. While entrepreneurial support organizations, organizations that provide support to individuals and collectives as they seek to start and grow their businesses [7], also afford opportunities for aspiring entrepreneurs to obtain informational and emotional support from their peers [7, 8, 35, 36, 42, 46], existing research suggests that aspiring entrepreneurs in financially constrained communities, especially those that are also minorities, may mistrust institutions based on their historical experiences of discrimination [4] and thus are less likely to employ peer support outside their community to support their entrepreneurial transitions.

Past HCI and CSCW research emphasizes the importance of psychological safety to help individuals feel comfortable disclosing their resource needs, especially while they navigate life transitions [18, 22, 32, 43]. Psychological safety refers to individuals' perceptions about the consequences of taking interpersonal risks in their environment including but not limited to asking questions, seeking feedback, and/or proposing a new idea [16]; in the context of work teams, enhanced psychological safety is associated with increased resource-seeking behaviors including help-seeking and feedback-seeking [16]. My prior work suggests that financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs prefer disclosing their resource needs in spaces they perceive as "safe" and may gravitate away from social media to disclose their resource needs and obtain feedback [31, 32]. Promisingly, past HCI and CSCW research cited the importance of community-based organizations (CBO) in fostering institutional trust and online interactions among strangers in financially-constrained communities [12–14, 20, 26, 31, 45]. However, it remains unclear how and whether CBO-supported interventions could facilitate the sense of safety to support financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' resource-seeking practices for their work-role transitions. And examining the factors that contribute to financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety and their resource-seeking practices remains largely under-explored.

Towards addressing this gap and developing a better understanding of how sociotechnical systems can support aspiring entrepreneurs' resource-seeking practices for their transitions, my dissertation aims to address the following questions:

- What factors *facilitate* and *deter* financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety as they seek resources to support their work-role transitions?
- How can existing sociotechnical systems support financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety as they seek resources to support their transitions?

2 RESEARCH GOALS, METHODS, RESULTS & CONTRIBUTIONS TO DATE

To address my dissertation research questions, I plan to leverage data collected from three studies. I have employed a combination of semi-structured interviews, observations, focus groups, and a

longitudinal survey, one of which is completed. I next discuss the three studies in more detail.

2.0.1 Study 1: Opportunities for Social Media to Support Aspiring Entrepreneurs with Financial Constraints. To explore how aspiring entrepreneurs from financially-constrained communities use social media for informational and emotional support as they navigate their transition to entrepreneurship and the challenges they face in doing so, I reanalyzed a sub-sample of 19 semi-structured interviews with individuals who were either small business owners or actively trying to become small business owners [32]. The data was taken from two empirical studies that took place in Metropolitan Detroit with the overarching goal of understanding aspiring small business owners' motivations for starting their businesses, their use of social platforms to support their business endeavors and how social technologies support and inhibit individuals' professional agency [27]. I re-analyzed this data, drawing from work-role transition scholarship to understand how aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained communities leverage social media for specific phases of their work-role transitions [28].

I found that aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained areas primarily use social media platforms to identify next steps to adapt to their desired entrepreneurial identities once they had an idea about the kind of entrepreneur they wanted to become. However, participants were less comfortable publicly disclosing their resource needs or seeking feedback on their ideas in online spaces that felt unsafe due to fears of discrimination, harassment, and uncertainty around community norms. Instead, participants described seeking feedback offline from other trusted individuals in their network or on closed Facebook Groups that encouraged a more supportive environment.

This study extended existing research on financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' use of social media [3, 27], contributing insights on how their resource-seeking practices limit them from obtaining feedback and resources online to support their transitions and the importance of psychological safety to facilitate their resource-seeking practices [32]. At the same time, this study raised future questions for research to address, which I aim to address in my dissertation. These include: *What factors contribute to financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety as they seek resources to support their transitions? How might sociotechnical interventions support and amplify the resource-seeking practices of financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs?*

2.0.2 Study 2: 'Keeping Each Other Accountable': Fostering Psychological Safety among Aspiring Entrepreneurs in Financially-Constrained Communities. In the second study of my dissertation, I build on the insights from the first study and draw from past HCI and CSCW research that has cited the importance of community-based organizations (CBO) to foster institutional and interpersonal trust and interactions among strangers in financially-constrained communities [12, 31]. I aimed to further unpack how sociotechnical interventions can support aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety and their resource-seeking practices of aspiring-entrepreneurs by evaluating a community-based organization-supported socio-technical system with a similar work-role transition lens as my first study.

In this study, I draw on my past study [31], which comprised of a series of semi-structured interviews, observations and focus groups

with members of a community-based organization, UpTogether. UpTogether is a community-based not-for-profit organization that aims to alleviating poverty in the United States by connecting low-income individuals and families so that they can work collectively to further their social and economic mobility [30]. To this end, UpTogether connects low-income individuals across the United States through its in-house developed social media platform, also called UpTogether, and offline UpTogether-sponsored events. Within each low-income community, UpTogether connects groups of families, referred to as “cohorts.”

I re-analyzed a subset of the data collected from this study - specifically transcripts and notes from 10 semi-structured interviews, three observations, and focus group sessions with three cohorts. I focused on re-analyzing interviews with UpTogether members who are aspiring entrepreneurs and focus group sessions with cohorts with at least one aspiring entrepreneur.

Participants primarily sought informational and emotional support, including feedback on their business ideas and tailored advice for their entrepreneurial goals, from cohort members whom they had established trusted relationships with offline. Factors that facilitated participants' sense of safety and their resource-seeking practices to support their transitions included shared identity, interpersonal trust, perceived expertise, and group norms of shared accountability. While I have completed data collection for this study, I am revisiting my analysis, examining how the factors that facilitated participants' sense of safety contribute to and extend existing theoretical frameworks including psychological safety.

2.0.3 Study 3: CBO-supported Peer Group Interactions for Aspiring Entrepreneurs. In the final study of my dissertation, I plan to build on the insights from the prior two studies; The first two studies highlight the importance of safety to facilitate resource-seeking among financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs, opportunities for small groups of trusted peers to foster safe spaces and factors that may facilitate this sense of safety and enable resource-seeking. However, in the second study, these groups were primarily formed by UpTogether members, not the UpTogether organization. UpTogether participants benefited from knowing and forming groups with other UpTogether members with similar entrepreneurial goals or expertise. However, aspiring in financially-constrained communities may not always have access to individuals in their network who are also entrepreneurs or are trying to become entrepreneurs [25, 33, 38].

This raises important questions, which I aim to address in my dissertation. These include: *How can a community-based organization help facilitate access to peers to support financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' work-role transitions, especially for those individuals that may have limited access or awareness of weak ties with entrepreneurial interests and/or expertise? And what factors impact whether these peer interactions facilitate aspiring entrepreneurs' resource-seeking behaviors?*

To address these questions, I partnered with the UpTogether organization on an 18-month longitudinal research study. The larger goal of this study is to evaluate how the UpTogether organization's pilot initiative in Oakland, CA facilitates resource exchange and social support among members, who all reside in the Oakland, CA area, a geographical area, which has a poverty rate of 30.4% and

a median household income of \$39,600 [9]. As a part of this pilot initiative, the UpTogether organization and the research team created 66 randomly assigned groups of 3-5 participants based on shared interests that included but were not limited to parenting, career development and entrepreneurship. Employing both surveys and semi-structured interviews, I plan to examine how the factors I previously identified (e.g., interpersonal trust) correlate with financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' resource-seeking practices among members of their assigned groups. I also plan to use the qualitative data gathered to better understand how community-based organization-supported platforms may be designed to foster a sense of safety and resource-seeking among participants.

Through this research, I aim to:

- Obtain a deeper understanding of the sociotechnical factors that contribute to the efficacy of CBO-supported peer group interventions for financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' work-role transitions, specifically those that facilitate a sense of psychological safety and resource-seeking among financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs
- Determine design directions for community-based organization-supported interventions and other socio-technical systems to support financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' work-role transition processes
- Identify methodological approaches to conducting remote longitudinal survey study with individuals in financially-constrained communities, contributing insights on ways to tailor recruitment and study design to lower barriers to participation

3 NEXT STEPS, CHALLENGES AND LONG-TERM GOALS

I am analyzing the data collected from my third study, revisiting the analysis I conducted in the second study, and exploring the strengths and limitations of different theoretical frameworks to apply, contribute to, and extend in my dissertation research. For instance, the theory of psychological safety seems to be an appropriate lens to understand financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' resource-seeking practices in the first two studies of my dissertation; the construct has been heavily used in the contexts of resource-seeking among teams and groups, and conceptually, the antecedents of this theory (e.g., interpersonal trust) seem to align with the insights generated in my research thus far. However, I did not measure this construct in the pilot survey of the third study in my dissertation. Thus, understanding how to apply this framework to my dissertation meaningfully is one challenge I'm currently navigating.

While I look for ways to employ and contribute toward theory in my dissertation, I aim to build on these insights and develop an agenda for future research, especially as I consider and apply for postdoctoral opportunities. My long-term goal is to be an academic researcher, using research to inform the design and development of sociotechnical interventions to support individuals in financially-constrained communities as they transition to alternate forms of work. To this end, I see three streams of research that I would like to build on in the future, building on the insights generated from my dissertation research thus far:

3.0.1 Participatory Design with Financially-Constrained Aspiring Entrepreneurs. My dissertation research primarily focuses on understanding financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs' experiences with sociotechnical systems that were designed *for* rather than *with* them. There are opportunities to extend this research methodologically and engage aspiring entrepreneurs in the process of designing and evaluating sociotechnical systems to support and amplify their resource-seeking practices for their work-role transitions. In the future, I envision employing a community-centered approach toward this research and employing collaborative methods (e.g., participatory design, photovoice, community voice) that elevate and center the voices of community members in the design process [17, 24]. Through more inclusive research methodologies, I will develop a better understanding of how sociotechnical interventions can better align with community member assets and values; at the same time, I will contribute methodological approaches to conducting community-centered approaches in financially-constrained communities.

3.0.2 Interrogating the Role of Shared Identity on Safety and Resource-Seeking with an Intersectional Lens. My dissertation has yielded conflicting insights on the role of shared identity in fostering a psychologically safe space and resource-seeking among financially-constrained aspiring entrepreneurs. In the second study of my dissertation, I found that perceived shared identity with other cohort members, fostered by shared values, roles, and social identities and challenges, facilitated participants' interpersonal trust towards their cohort members and their comfort in disclosing their resource needs during group meetings. Yet, in some of my early dissertation survey findings, I'm finding a negative association between shared identity and participants' resource-seeking behaviors; in some cases, cultural norms may inhibit individuals with shared ethnic identities from sharing information. While I am in the process of reconciling the differences in these findings, I see an opportunity to further interrogate the role of shared identity on aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety and resource-seeking practices. Using an intersectional lens, I envision qualitatively and quantitatively exploring the impact of shared identity on aspiring entrepreneurs' sense of safety and their resource-seeking practices in different locations, cultures, and contexts.

3.0.3 Generative AI for Work-Role Transitions. While social media remain a source of informational and emotional support for many aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained communities [3, 27, 32], they are not the only tools available to support their transitions. Technologies that leverage generative AI, such as ChatGPT are emerging as avenues to obtain relevant information quickly with minimal training and social interaction [21, 41].

While existing HCI research suggests that such technologies can be leveraged to increase productivity in business tasks [41] and support ideation [21], which could be beneficial for aspiring entrepreneurs, there is limited research on how such technologies may be adopted and perceived by aspiring entrepreneurs in financially-constrained communities to support their transitions. It is also unclear how the pitfalls with such technologies (e.g., bias, nonfactual responses) [34] may complicate their abilities to use such tools for their transitions. I hope to build on this prior work, examining

the current (and potential) role of generative artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies for work-role transitions.

4 RESEARCH SITUATION & DISSERTATION STATUS

I'm a 5th year PhD Candidate at the University of Michigan's School of Information, advised by Prof. Tawanna Dillahunt. I plan to defend my dissertation by the Fall of 2024. I have not attended any other doctoral consortia during my tenure as a PhD student. While I have made progress toward my dissertation, there are many directions that I can take to analyze the data collected and expand and build upon my work. I am eager to get feedback from the CHI D.C. community on ways to approach my dissertation analysis and theoretical framing and expand my future work. Moreover, I hope to build a community with my fellow D.C. cohort - connections I hope to maintain and collaborate with beyond the consortium.

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